STARTLING LIBRARY STORIES

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LIQUID DAMAGE

by AW

The green slime started on the ceiling. Albert didn't notice it at first, until one day he woke up to a wet thud on his face. He opened his eyes and stared up at the spot above his bed where the slime had started to drip. What was this? he wondered, still half asleep. It had a stickiness to it that felt somewhat familiar. Ignoring it for the time being, Albert rolled over to the other side of his bed to avoid any more interruptions to his sleep.

Waking up the next morning, Albert slowly forced himself out of bed. His foot searched for his slipper, but instead it landed in what felt like a puddle of mush. This sent a shock of cold through his body and he was suddenly alert now. He lifted up his foot to see what he had stepped in and a slimy green substance stretched along with it. In fact, his entire bedroom floor was covered in it and was slowly seeping out the door towards the rest of his apartment. What was going on!? His entire bedroom was covered in the slime he noticed. Everything, except for one item that sat dry as a bone on his bedroom dresser —a library book he had borrowed a few days back. How did the book avoid being covered in this sludge? There was only one way to find out…

When Albert arrived at the library, the doors still had not yet opened. He looked anxiously at his watch. It's basically 9:30am! Why weren't they open yet? he fumed. He could see the librarians chatting away on the inside. HURRY UP AND OPEN ALREADY, he wanted to scream.

He painstakingly watched as the librarian sauntered over to slowly unlock the gates. As soon as the sliding glass doors opened, the herd of people waiting alongside him rushed inside. Albert went right up to the Information Desk where a young woman sat typing away on her computer.

"Excuse me?" he said. "I wonder if you can help me out. I'm having this problem at home and… well, it's weird."

The librarian smiled warmly. "Weird, huh? Do you happen to have coffee or beer dripping from your ceiling?"

"Uh, not quite," said Albert, startled, "but you're very close. It's like some weird green slime substance."

"Oh," the librarian's smile dropped. "I see."

Albert explained that his whole room was covered in it and that it was spreading throughout his apartment, but that the only thing that wasn't covered in it was his library book. He held out the book for the librarian to see.

Putting on a pair of latex gloves, she gingerly took the book from him between her fingers. Flipping through the pages, she eventually stopped midway through. "Is this yours?" she asked, turning the book to him to show him the page. She pointed at the corner of the page.

"Uhh….?" Albert responded, slightly confused.

"This right here," she pointed at a spot in the corner of the page. "Did you or did you not pick your nose and wipe your snot on the inside of this book on this page?"

Albert turned beet red. "I-I..."he stammered. "There was no Kleenex around… I…."

"You didn't think anyone would notice? You didn't think that the person who borrowed this book after you would know what it was? You see, sir, we have developed a new technology here at the library that detects any kind of liquid damage done to our books," she told him sternly. "Whatever type of substance lands on our books, it is reproduced and shot out into the air and takes over the person's home, usually beginning on the ceiling. For example, if you spill coffee on a book, your whole apartment would be flooded with coffee within 72 hours. Some people who cry while reading a sad story will wake up the next day to find saltwater dripping down the walls. In your case though, it seems you have been slimed by your own snot."

"What do I do? How do I get rid of it? I need it to stop!" Albert exclaimed, frightened.

The librarian calmly replied, "You just need to hire some cleaners to clean it up. It will stop spreading and won't come back – unless you do this again of course. Also you will need to go up to the Circulation Desk and pay a fine for damaging this book. Have a good day, sir. I hope you have learned your lesson."

After that, Albert took the utmost care of his library books from that point on.

The Creepy Cabinet Card

by Sarika Kelm

Annalisa Aninang was too intelligent to be a processing archivist in a muggy Boston basement. She longed for something more intellectually stimulating, but other employers had yet to appreciate her unique temperament. Annalisa was the kind of archivist who responded to "What exactly does an ar-CHIVE-ist do?" with a smile and correction—"AR-chiv-ist"—before enthralling the asker with her explanations about *respect des fonds* and original order. Her audience was usually confused at first, but then their eyes would eventually light up. "Oh! A librarian of old things!" Annalisa would either cringe or sigh.

"It's more complicated than that," she'd insist.

"But that's kinda what you are, right? You catalogue things like a librarian does."

"I *arrange and describe* records." The baffled expressions that followed her rehearsed spiel about the difference between intellectual and physical arrangements made her feel rather smug about her education.

Annalisa was sitting at her cramped processing table when she found the book. She had just tweeted about how humid it was in her workspace, how it was awful for the records. The truth was that she didn't really care about the records of rich people. Rich people were boring. The owner of the book was probably boring.

"This book belongs to Mrs. Adam Bachiler," Annalisa read out loud, pleased at her ability to decipher handwriting, which was a dying skill. Her cotton gloves made it difficult to turn the fragile pages. She continued reading.

Sunday, October 3, 1897

Adam preached a wonderful sermon today. I wore the dress he bought for me to church and received many compliments. Mrs. Young said burgundy suits me well. Belinda

Tuesday, October 5, 1897

Rained all day. We stayed indoors and the children and I enjoyed apple pie, which I had the cook make from the apples Adam's brother sent over yesterday from his orchard. Belinda

"She sounds like a boring housewife," Annalisa murmured, fanning through the remaining pages with a gloved thumb. She hated how precise the handwriting was—perfectly straight on unlined pages. A *carte-de-visite* or cabinet card fell out of the pages of the diary and landed in Annalisa's lap. She picked it up and groaned (inserts were always bothersome to describe). The photograph was of a woman—probably *Mrs. Adam* Bachiler—with a very conservative collar and intricate bun pinned high on her head. Her expression was that of a woman who had been sitting too long. ("What an ugly dress," remarked the archivist, wondering if it was burgundy). Annalisa could almost see the corners of her lips twitch—wait, they *did* twitch! She blinked hard and narrowed her eyes at the photograph again.

"You!" the woman in the photograph said, turning her head and looking directly at Annalisa who dropped the portrait into the diary. "No, you *look* at me! I heard what you said." Belinda tsked. "Boring! I'm not boring. You're boring!"

"Wh—what?"

"Ugly!" the photograph screeched. The face looked a little hurt. "You don't even know me. You don't know me well enough to say that about me. How dare you! How dare you read my diary and think those things about me."

"I… I'm sorry!"

"I curse you!" the sepia horror spat, throwing down the prop chair that had been beside her.

"I don't understand."

"I CURSE YOU!" Belinda Bachiler bellowed. "Your records will be erased! You won't be able to create new ones!" With that, Annalisa flung the photograph at the air in front of her and ran out of the basement.

After work, Annalisa went to the store to buy milk and the receipt would not print. When she opened the door to her apartment, she saw that the framed photographs on her walls were blank if she had been in them. With her free hand, she fumbled in her purse for her day

planner—and it was as if she had never written in it. She dropped the milk on the floor and hurried to her desk where there was a pen and paper.

My name is Annalisa Aninang and I am not a librarian

The shaky letters faded before her eyes. What had that Victorian witch done? Annalisa began sobbing. She wandered into her bedroom and fell across her bed, startling her cat. “Who am I if I can’t tell other people who I am?” she wailed. Her cat meowed indifferently and made a new bed in the laundry hamper.

The end… ?

lily pads and frogs to Trappist-1

by intQ

I am part of the 5th generation on this starship that was loosely based on the mechanics of lily pads and frogs to Trappist-1.

I am part of the librarian team, ensuring that those aboard this ship have access to enough history and culture that if anything goes wrong with the attempted resettlement the mistakes of the past will not be repeated. Or as some of my colleagues like to say, "if this all goes pear shaped, the poor fools that weren't lucky 'nuf to die quick aren't cursed to relive the dark ages on the far side of the universe".

We encourage every shipborn to remember lessons from our collective past; once we all shared a background of some form of "hostile dystopias where the odds of survival can be almost insurmountable" (we also of course hope that the generations to come will read Octavia E. Butler's works and the many that she inspired).

We as a collective envision a world without war, without prisons, without capitalism, we are lucky to live this dream on this starship, and hopeful that our descendants will expand this dream to fill and tend like bees on a planet.

Sometimes I will joke with those on my team about cataloging or classifying, how the word "antelope" is just a collection of letters, a construct, but the DNA that we have to create what animals are collectively agreed upon to be recreated that DNA of an antelope is real.

Am I right thinking this? I will re-read *The Minimum Population Sizes for Species Conservation* by Mark L. Shaffer and ask the committee…

UBER

by Joseph S. Pete

Nick hailed the ride-sharing car to the bar where he had pounded seven craft beers, all well above 6 percent ABV and hopped aggressively and bitterly to current tastes.

"Let me close out," he slurred to the bartender. "For real this time."

Clyde watched from inside the library stacks, in a comfy leather chair by the fourth-floor windows at the end of the magazine section where a hand-inscribed sign told patrons to head to the main desk to check out newspapers with an ID because of all the recent thefts, including of removed ads and torn-out articles, as Nick stumbled outside of the neon-lit windows of the bar into the parking lot and scanned around hopelessly, until a black sedan slid up to the curb. He yanked on the door and clambered in the back seat.

The car accelerated before Nick even settled in, before he snapped on his seatbelt.

"Hey, what the hell?"

He glared up at the front seat and saw there was no driver to shower his disapproval on.

"An autonomous, eh?" he sneered. "Well, get me back to 1260 Lakefront Avenue."

Then he realized the car probably already had his address, from when he entered it into the app, along with his phone number, credit card information and who knew what else. He had surrendered everything, instantly and unthinkingly, all in the name of convenience. He realized the car likely already knew where he lived, that his whole identity was out there, floating around in the cloud.

Nick hated being chauffeured around by an inert hunk of metal that rolled off the assembly line. But it was better than facing a DUI. There was a creepily impersonal element to it, but he still appreciated gliding out into the oncoming flow of traffic, under the glowing streetlamps with little more direction than an initial command. It felt regal, like he was being ferried around on a palanquin by oiled, muscled servants.

“Uber, play NPR,” he barked.

He preferred the dulcet, commercial-free morphine drip of National Public Radio. It soothed him, generally. But they were prattling again on about the latest in a series of outrages in Washington D.C. and he was so battered down by all the endless fusillades of bad news that left one with so little hope for humanity he couldn’t bear it anymore. He was done.

“Uber, play B96,” he sighed.

“I’m afraid I can’t do that Nick.”

“What the hell,” he muttered almost under his breath.

That’s when the car abruptly veered right directly through the guardrail and off the bridge.

It plunged and plunged and plunged and plunged for what seemed like forever, before violently smacking into the ground. Nick’s neck snapped back as he was flung about like a rag doll. The car flipped, and flipped again. He felt upended, like gravity was magically suspended, like the end of the world came hurtlingly in a 45 mph zone.

“What the hell.”

He was badly battered, sprawled out in the crumbled car on the train tracks.

A glaring train light shone down the tracks.

“Uber, please…”

He spat up blood halfway through the vocal command, felt the warm sticky substance on his lips. Nick suddenly realized he was seriously wounded, maybe fatally. More blood trickled out of his slack mouth.

“Uber…”

Clyde, whose shift as a reference librarian had ended 43 minutes ago, jammed his finger down on a directional key on his keyboard. The car’s wheels spun and it galloped down the track, toward the oncoming train.

He had been hired to take out Nick. By whom he didn't know, but it was still a big payday. He was a librarian by day/hacker by night who never attempted anything like this before but knew that self-driving cars had many points of entry. It was all even easier than he anticipated.

A voice on the intercom declaimed that the library was closing in 15 minutes and anyone with items to check

out should head up to the main desk. Clyde didn't sweat the interruption. Everything was already in motion. And the bar this buffoon had staggered out of had free wifi, so he could see it out. Clyde packed his stuff up in his messenger bag and strode down the escalator, with a little spring in his step.

On his laptop down in the bar, as he tore into a Buffalo wing, slurping up the last tendon of meat, Clyde pressed down on the enter key, flooding the gas. The train was puttering along at only a few miles per hour at this point, but it weighed thousands of tons.

“Hon, do you want another beer?” the waitress asked.

“I think we're done here.”

Metal twisted, grimaced and sighed as Nick's Uber smacked headlong into the train engine car.

“You have reached your final destination,” was the last thing Nick ever heard, as the maps app on his phone chirped unexpectedly.

orccupations

by RJ Edwards

Library Orc

travelogue

by Zach Welhouse

To Whom it May Concern:

As publishers of tenacity and dread, I am uncertain whether your periodical will be interested in a summary of my tour of the continent's more particular libraries. Nevertheless, I take the augers of the Buckram Hag under serious advisement. The good woman's gummy susurrations to write you were as explicit as I have heard from her lips. Perhaps her wardens had provided an extra helping of night-gruel or the autumnal wildwind, which guards her slumber, had unseasonably muted its maddening whine. No matter the source, you now see the results before you.

In my lighter moments, I do imagine my experiences in the stacks may be instructive to ametuer archivists; as decorum prevails against her tawdry twin, I chastise myself for engaging in alliteration and fancy. The summaries provided below lack in structure and purpose. They are idleness, and thus wickedness. However, they exist, like any printed work to be cataloged and forgotten. I present you not with the fecund eternal specimens of the Antelope Archive, but with imperfect, impermanent recollections. They are dead words on a dismal page, which recount a past already obscured by that old miser, Memory.

Be that as it may, each labor is its own reward. Here is my story. Make of it what you will.

~

Following a recent altercation with a patron over the correct application of a little-loved style guide, my esteemed superior made note the coming summer would be the perfect opportunity to divest myself of accumulated holiday time. I do not treasure leaving the Archive, especially as foaling season is near. Nevertheless, it should not be said Tancy Givens cannot recognize a clue. Until Mr. B_____ is able to find the inner peace he sorely lacks, my opinions and my presence were unwanted.

With no relatives of note and a deep aversion to leisure for leisure's sake, the much-mildewed hermitage by

Tsukar Lake was not an option. A distant aunt once convinced me to attend a holiday soiree at her landlord's extravagantly priced seaside hotel. However, I must have mistaken her directions, as I instead found myself vacationing in an abandoned cracker factory. Without further options, I spent the better part of a week putting its registers in order. The factory has been re-opened on account of my oversight and, thus, is no longer accepting boarders.

I was half-resolved to spend my holiday in the peat bog on the outskirts of the Archive grounds, when Luck flashed his vulgar smile and presented me with a map elsewhere. The Archive keeps a closet of monographs donated by well-intentioned beneficiaries, who act under the mistaken impression our institution cares about books. Acolytes dust the donations every solstice to insure they are outwardly presentable on the rare occasion their former owners brave the journey to our sanctum.

Vast sheaves of these tomes are fit only to teach acolytes the virtues of monotony and penitence. The lessons I learned from my youth of dusting could fill a set of tomes, which would summarily be dusted by the next generation of acolytes. No acolyte ever opens the books in the Dusting Closet, as colophon worms have been known to nest in the older volumes. Acolytes are not allowed protective gloves until their third year, to teach the importance of prudence, so most do their utmost to avoid the pests.

It has been years since I have worn the acolyte's starched shift or weighted mask, so the colophon worms were no deterrent the night I found my map. Indeed, I had developed a taste for the vermin during a period of convalescence. Each worm is as long as an ape's smallest finger, and offers great succor when the body's subtle acts of defiance explode into open rebellion. When properly pressed, the morsels feel akin to a firm persimmon and bear the taste of vinegar tar with a hint of lilac.

The night I discovered the map was poor worming. In their stead, I found a sparse map between the leaves of a folio. The map's broad outlines depicted the familiar shape of the continent, but its interior was less familiar. In lieu of the commonplace political boundaries and names of cities were illustrations of buildings

drawn in a measured, elegant hand. The cartographer who penned this work was a skilled draftsman, but lacked the dedication to truth required by one of his craft. These buildings were connected with amorphous lines, which did not represent roads, rivers, or any terrestrial phenomenon. Instead, each bore the legend of a madman.

"Dreams," read one line. "Fear," read another. These were battle lines, bare boulevards for ideas! Each triumphant building on the map was as a barbarian general, presiding over a rabble of notions. If these buildings were real, they were libraries.

~

The buildings on the map were libraries. In time, I grew to know them. I walked each library, learning its heroism and heresies. Several of the buildings indicated on the map had vanished by the time I visited, transformed to ruin. Other libraries surprised me, crouched hidden in towns where none were indicated on the map. It was tempting to trust the old cartographer's ways, for he directed me to such wonders. Yet each delight brought further questions, sharpened knives, and regret. The old cartographer was not infallible. Ink does not contain the truth. Flesh speaks, blood roars.

The Archive's lessons remain inscribed on my bones. They persevere where other collections struggle. The fallen nations of the continent are fallow fields for new thought. Their libraries are not abattoirs, but mausoleums. The walking dead cry not for the knowledge in their care; they would do better to tend the living's cry for meat.

Three of the countless archives I visited are worthy of continued study. I have prepared a brief sketch describing each of them.

~

The Caviary is heard before it is seen. Shrill squeaks guide the travel to its cedar halls as if forming roads cobbled in crystallized sound. The librarians met me at the door with a beard fashioned of pine needles. "Bare faces are not permitted," they warned. They were not unkind, but nevertheless intractable. I wore the prickly beard, aware that one in three librarians were similarly attired. The others were saved the indignity by nature's graces.

The scriptorium is the Caviary's most exercised muscle. It is here the librarians paint works of spectacular beauty and endless insight onto the squirming bodies of hairless guinea pigs. The creatures are complacent during the painting, responding as if they are being groomed by others in their herd. Nature, although red in tooth and claw, is not without her puckish jests. Were I to meet her one star-blighted night, I would most assuredly keep my eyes open and my good hand in my pocket, wrapped around a solid length of pipe.

The specimens of the recording medium are like any hairless guinea pig you may have seen, but for their broad wings. They are as a bird's wings, capable of short bursts of flight. Watching one of these beasts fumble its way through the air is an indignity on the observer as well as the observed. The best that can be said is flying allows the works on the creatures' lumpen bodies to be viewed at eye level, albeit briefly.

The staff of the Caviary is overworked. Librarians are required to retouch their work every few days, as their charges lick the information from one another. The staff further over-spends its labor copying texts from the bodies of the old and wrinkled onto the bodies of the young. The young are just as wrinkled as their elders, but their skin is more pliable and easier to read.

The most instructive element of the enterprise is its catalog. The squeaking, skitting creatures are always out of order, causing even the simplest research question a challenge. The head librarian explained, "We have always done it this way. The rodent haberdashers who fund us are quite specific in their grant requirements." One can only imagine the librarians could construct a flexible taxonomy if the works were to wear hats identifying their relationships. This plan had been tried and failed on multiple occasions, resulting only chewed-through chinstraps, an increase in airborne collisions, and an agitated, hopping reference collection.

~

The Museum of Light proved less itchy than the Caviary, but its works were just as difficult to grasp. My first encounter with the museum's elusive subject matter occurred on the mosaic pathway leading through the

enclave's succulent garden. The path was formed of smooth glass fragments connected by a smooth sealant. Among the squat garden of cacti and burro's tail, the path caught and diffracted the sun's rays. I took my time approaching the museum, enjoying the oppressive weight of the sun.

The Museum of Light's primary edifice consists of a four-story adobe mound attached to a dome panelled with stained glass. Despite the building's bulk, it is open and airy by dint of its wide, glassless windows. Natural light floods the museum's rooms according to the schedule of the sun and stars, illuminating different collections at different times.

Observant readers may question the wisdom of including a museum on a list of prominent libraries. This idolatrous inclusion was answered by the head attendant, a woman who carried a patchwork umbrella. She explained many of the articles in the collection were available for members to check out. The misleading title is an artifice of the museum's owners. As a family of considerable wealth, the owners wish to maintain cordial relations with those who are tied to the region. When the owners make their yearly visit, they wear wide belts and turbans in the local fashion and speak in overwrought regionalisms. The most popular, "Did m'you see, um…", is applied to any object or collection of objects that provokes wonder. While the local populace is not known for their love of wordplay, it is not a skinnable offense as it is in my distant home.

Most of the museum's collection consists of shattered panes of glass that have been remounted in stone settings. Light flows through the glass to illuminate the variegated floor. The quality of mid-day light shining through Porcini's *Bearing Factory #12* on a tableau of lead tiles is completely different than that of Choudary's *Untitled* on a bed of broken brick. The attendants assure me this is true.

The side galleries are the one section of the museum that are not lit by external sources. Through ingenious artifice, the attendants have derived a method of bottling light in glass jars. For instance, a plum-colored teardrop may glow with the luminescence of a bottled eclipse. A nearby flute of crimson crackles with the dying embers of a bonfire. I was surprised to see a

visiting student sleeping in front of the latter bottle. If the museum attendants' beliefs about the quality of light can be believed, the student had discovered a soporific vintage.

[[From this point, the correspondence is damaged. We have reconstructed it from fragments that appear to be chewed.]

~

Draymish & Orm, Ltd. [...] a very particular mail order transcription service. Unclaimed [illegible] available for browsing. Clients provide wax cylinders bearing rectangular chansons [?] The lavender-gloved clerks use typewriters that possess human teeth instead of writing heads. (Are pieces of meat its medium? Some succulent leather? Regardless, the interior is strangely organic.) [...] The Ravenous Scribes! Take care around the dromadraries [...] mobile camel-libraries [...] velour concavity for both tender and cargo [?] terrible chafing [...] extreme discomfort.

~

My travels complete, I returned to the Archive. It is my intent to never again leave.

It is with great trepidation that I end this missive and send it forth to its grave.

With fondest regards,

Tancy Givens-Smythe
Glass Candle Initiate
The Antelope Archive

A Cataloging Carol

by Catherine Oliver

Stave I.

AACR2 was dead: to begin with. There is no doubt whatever about that. Old AACR2 was as dead as a door-nail.

MARC knew he was dead? Of course he did. How could it be otherwise? AACR2 and he were partners for I don't know how many years.

Oh! But he was a strict one at the OCLC Validate button, MARC! a confusing, strict, limited, rigid old content standard! No cataloger ever looked at a MARC record and said, with a gladsome look, "My dear MARC, how are you?" But what did MARC care! It was the very thing he liked.

Once upon a time—of all the good years in the world, on the night before Banned Books Week began—old MARC sat busy in his documentation. A window was open that he might keep his eye upon his cataloger, who in a dismal little cell beyond was doing copy cataloging.

"A happy Banned Books Week, uncle! Ranganathan save you!" cried a cheerful voice. It was the voice of MARC's nephew, MODS.

"Bah!" said MARC. "Invalid!"

"Banned Books Week invalid, uncle?" asked MODS. "You don't mean that, I am sure?"

"I do," said MARC. "Happy Banned Books Week? What right have you to be happy?"

"What right have you to be unhappy?" returned MODS. "You're granular enough."

MARC having no better answer ready on the spur of the moment said "Bah!" again; and followed it up with "Invalid."

"Don't be cross, uncle."

"What else can I be when I live in such a world of reference librarians as this? If I could work my will," said MARC indignantly, "every idiot who goes about with 'Happy Banned Books Week!' on his lips should be impaled on his own Banned Books Week display and buried with a copy of *Ulysses* in his mouth. He should!"

"I am sure I have always thought of Banned Books Week, when it has come round—apart from the veneration due to its sacred name and origin—as a good time; a kind, forgiving, charitable, pleasant time; a time when people think about the mission of librarianship," said MODS.

The cataloger involuntarily applauded. Becoming immediately sensible of the impropriety, he sorted a spreadsheet.

"Let me hear another sound from you," said MARC to the cataloger, "and you'll never get another subject heading approved again!"

"I am sorry, with all my heart, to find you so resolute," said MODS. "But I'll keep my Banned Books Week humor to the last. So Happy Banned Books Week, uncle!"

"Good afternoon!" said MARC.

"And a good Annual Conference!"

"Good afternoon!" said MARC.

The cataloger, in letting MODS out, had let two other people in. They were portly persons, and they bowed to MARC.

"At this festive season of the year," said one of them, "it is more than usually desirable that we should update the standard. You are—forgive me!—confusing."

"Are there no machine-generated records? Is there no Dublin Core?"

"There are; but many can't use those, and many would rather die."

"If they would rather die," said MARC, "they had better do it, and decrease the competition for cataloging jobs."

The persons withdrew, and MARC set once again to work. At length the hour of keyword regeneration came.

"You'll want all week next week, I suppose?" said MARC.

"If quite convenient," said Bob Cataloger.

"It is not convenient." said MARC. "Be here all the earlier next week!"

MARC went home* through the dark streets. As he laid his hand upon his doorknob, he saw, not a doorknob, but *the instruction pertaining to the rule of three*.

"Bah!" said MARC. "Invalid!"

* *Don't ask.*

But he trembled a little.

He spent the whole evening thinking he saw AACR2—or worse, AACR2 Revised!—at every corner. Finally, he went to bed.*

The door flew open with a booming sound, and then he heard a noise, a noise like many people flipping pages and cursing simultaneously as they tried to catalog treaties, coming up the stairs, straight towards his door.

"It's invalid still!" said MARC. "I won't believe it."

His mood changed, though, when, without a pause, a ghost bibliographic record—not a holdings or an item record to be seen!—came through the heavy door and passed into the room before his eyes.

"You are AACR2, my partner!" cried MARC.

"I was AACR2, your partner," it responded in sepulchral tones.

"You are fettered," said MARC, trembling. "Tell me why."

"I wear the Library of Congress Rule Interpretations I inspired in life," replied the Ghost.

"You always were a good content standard, AACR2," faltered MARC.

"I did not help catalogers sufficiently!" the ghost cried. "I am here to tell you that you have a chance of escaping my fate."

"You always were a good friend, AACR2," said MARC.

"You will be haunted," resumed the Ghost, "by Three Spirits."

"Still obsessed with the number three?" MARC feebly jested.

The Ghost screamed; and MARC, terrified, went straight to bed, without undressing**, and fell asleep upon the instant.

Stave II.

MARC awoke in the night to a strange radiance in the room. Looking up he saw, to his terror, another ghost bib. But, looking at it more closely, he was cheered by its gentle appearance. It had a redolence of cuneiform tablets, of manuscripts, of precise beige cards.

"I am the Ghost Bib of Cataloging Past," it said.

"Long past?" asked MARC.

** Again, don't ask.*

*** Look, what do you want of me?*

"Not tonight," said the Ghost. "Your past."

The Ghost grasped MARC and together they sailed through the clouds. Finally they arrived at a lonely schoolhouse. All the children had left for their break except one sad little boy, who sat miserably staring out the window.

But what was this! A small girl was driving up in a carriage!

"Fan!" cried the little boy.

"I have wonderful news! I have come to bring you home, dear brother!" she said, clapping her tiny hands.

"Home, little Fan?" returned the boy.

"Yes! Home for good and all. Father is so much kinder than he used to be, that home's like heaven!"

The little boy cried with joy.

"But what has brought about this change in him, Fan?" he asked.

"I don't quite understand it—something called MARC? They won't need to have catalog cards any more. Father keeps saying 'Electric erasers? Screw 'em!' and 'No more paper cuts!' and laughing like a man in a dream."

"Their father is a cataloger!" exclaimed MARC.

"Did you not notice the low standards they held him to? Could he be anything but a cataloger or a 'moderate' US senator?"

"And I brought such happiness into the family?"

"That you did, MARC, though you scarcely knew it! Now let me show you your own past."

Again they traversed the haze, until they reached a beautiful marble building.

"The Library of Congress!" cried MARC. "My childhood home!"

There was a cataloger party going on. They knew this because everyone was either wearing giant sparkly hats while doing an updated Charleston or hiding in the corners pretending to check their cell phones, a process made harder by the fact that cell phones had not yet been invented.

"Why, there I am!" cried MARC. "Look how young I appear. Why, I must still have been USMARC! And there are

my friends, CANMARC and UNIMARC!"

He bit his lip suddenly.

"What happened to them?" asked the Ghost casually.

"I ate them," muttered MARC.

He felt a certain sadness.

"You *ate* them?" asked the Ghost.

"I absorbed them, rather. Look," cried MARC defensively, "it had to be done! MARC had to be brought into the twenty-first century! I had no choice!"

The Ghost said nothing. MARC gazed again at the party-goers.

"Why, bless my soul, it's Henriette Avram again!" he cried. "My creator!"

"She created you?" asked the Ghost. "That must have cost her much time and effort."

"It did," said MARC. "But she was a wonderful person. She fought for bibliographic control, even when discouraged!"

"Why?" asked the Ghost.

"Why, she wanted access to all materials to be easy. She-"

MARC stopped.

"I wish I had been kinder to Bob Cataloger," he muttered. "He provides access all day and gets nothing but scorn from all quarters."

MARC gazed again upon the scene. Suddenly he could no longer bear it.

"Spirit!" he begged. "Let me return! Let me return, I say!"

He reached out and began to tear up the cards, manuscripts, and tablets. The more he tore, the more appeared, and he sank exhausted to the ground.

Stave III.

MARC awoke again, in his own bed, but this time because of a voice, resonant but indistinct, in the next room.

"Can this be the second ghost bib that was promised me?" he asked himself.

He went into the main room of his home and rubbed his eyes. The room was entirely transformed! Bookshelves filled it now from floor to ceiling, bookshelves piled with every banned or challenged book imaginable. And in the center sat a jolly giant of a bib record, remarkably detailed

and rich in subject headings and other access points.

Just to look at such a wonderful record made MARC feel warm. Then he noticed another reason to feel warm. There was a vast fire in the middle of the room! Books filled the fire, but they remained intact and pristine.

"Look upon me!" commanded the Ghost Bib. "I am the Ghost of Cataloging Present! Have you met me before?"

"No."

"Or any of my siblings? Diversity? Fetus? Transgender? Vulnerable? Entitlement? Science-Based? Evidence-Based?"

"I- I don't think so. What original minds your parents had!"

"'Twas not they who named us."

MARC blinked, then continued, "I see you celebrate Banned Books Week."

"That I do, all the year 'round. I make the inaccessible open to all, for such is my calling."

"If you wish to make books accessible, why burn them?" asked MARC, pointing to the fire.

"Manuscripts don't burn, man! Have you never read *The Master and Margarita* during your Banned Books Week celebration?"

"No," said MARC, a little ashamed.

"No matter," said the Ghost. "Let us go abroad and see how others celebrate."

Together they walked the streets, where they observed the Banned Books Week festivities. People wearing ALA T-shirts greeted others in novelty Banned Books Week socks. Stores did a brisk business in books and coffee mugs.

Eventually they wound up at a little hovel in the Tech Services part of town.

"Why," cried MARC, "there's Bob Cataloger!"

Bob was laying the plates for a glorious Banned Books Week dinner, complete with fancy novelty cake. In came a little orphan heading. Bob scooped it up.

"Well, Tiny Tim," he said, with a loving smile, "shall we sit down to our Library Cake?"

MARC wiped away a tear.

"The poor fellow is indeed tiny," he observed. "Not a reference—not a single reference—to be seen."

"A Happy Banned Books Week to us all!" said Bob.

"Ours is essentially a tragic age, so we refuse to take it tragically!" cried Tiny Tim.

And they set in to eat.

"Spirit," said MARC, "will Tiny Tim be spared?"

"I see a blank space in ClassWeb," said the Ghost, "where a little orphan heading used to be."

"Oh, no!" protested MARC. "Surely we can do authority work, so that poor Tiny Tim may have broader, narrower, and related terms?"

"That would take a great deal of time and effort," said the Ghost. "Surely you agree that time and effort put into metadata is wasted. Are there no machine-generated records? Is there no Dublin Core?"

MARC flinched, hearing his own words, and the Ghost disappeared.

Stave IV.

MARC looked about him for the Ghost of Cataloging Present, and saw it not. Lifting up his eyes, he beheld a solemn phantom, draped and hooded, coming along the ground like a mist towards him.

The Phantom was terrible to behold. Unlike the last, it had no distinguishing features. Only the title was present, and that with the article, impeding any left-anchored search. The format was given half a dozen different ways, none of them complying to any recognized standard.

"Are...are you the Spirit of Cataloging Yet to Come?"

The ghost bib nodded.

"I hate to look upon you," said MARC. "But lead the way. I know my time is short."

They entered what appeared to be the wealthy area of town, where administrators lived.

"So he's dead, is he?" said one higher-up to another.

"He is indeed," said the other. "Retrospective conversion just finished at my library. And it cost a pretty penny, I can tell you!"

The first administrator groaned.

"We'll recoup it by laying staff off," said the second. "It isn't as bad as it sounds. And we're hoping to get funding for a new Maker Commons soon."

The first brightened.

"A 3-D printer!" he said, excited.

"AND beanbag chairs."

Both smiled.

MARC gasped at the values on display.

"Surely someone feels some emotion at this death, and is not just thinking of the beanbag chairs and 3-D printers they can get out of it?" he asked the Spirit.

The Spirit led him on.

He saw a group of ill-dressed persons, obviously from LITA*, sitting around a pub and singing bawdy songs of migration and batch-editing.

"'E's gone at last!" one cried.

"That 'e is!" agreed another, calling lustily for another pint and slapping at the bugs in his code.

"Drinks on me, boys!" cried a man coming in. "The old b----- 's snuffed it!"

"Cheers, Mr. Tennant!" cried one of the systems personnel, as the pub exploded in joy.

"I can watch no longer," said MARC, disgusted. "Who has inspired such contempt, Spirit? Who has died?"

The Ghost pulled out a tablet and typed https://www.loc.gov/marc/ into the search bar. It came back with a 404.

"No, Spirit!" cried MARC. "No!"

"I'll be a better standard! I'll update! I'll celebrate Banned Books Week all year 'round by providing access to all materials!"

The Spirit backed up.

"I'LL GET RID OF ISBD PUNCTUATION!" screamed MARC, grabbing at the Spirit. But the record was deleted as he grasped it.

Stave V.

MARC awoke to find that he was clutching his own ILS. He stumbled to the window and called to a small passerby.

"Lad!" he cried. "What day is this?"

** IT WAS A JOKE LITA IS A GREAT ORGANIZATION PLEASE DON'T TAKE MY ILS OFF THE SERVER WONDERFUL SYSTEMS PEOPLE.*

"Why, it's the first day of Banned Books Week, sir!"

"Then I haven't missed it!" said MARC to himself. "I haven't missed it!"

He dressed and rushed out of the house to his nephew MODS's home.

"My dears," he said, when MODS and his spouse RIMMF opened the door, "I am sorry I have been so rigid and legalistic."

"Uncle!" cried MODS. "We are hosting a Jane-a-thon for Banned Books Week later. Come and celebrate with us!"

"Will I be in the way?" asked MARC dubiously.

"Of course not! We'd love to have you."

"I will be there. First I have something I must do."

He stopped at the baker's shop.

"I'd like the largest library cake you have," he said.

"The one I put on Facebook that got shared with every librarian whose relatives happened to spot it?" asked the baker.

"Yes! That big one!"

MARC took the cake with him and went to Bob Cataloger's house. Bob, looking careworn, opened the door, then stepped back, his eyes wide.

"MARC!" he said.

"Forgive me, Bob. I have come to make everything right. Tiny Tim must be an orphan heading no more."

Tiny Tim came rushing in.

"Is that the big library cake?" he cried. "The one from Facebook?"

"It is!" said MARC. "Let us eat it together and post pictures of it on Instagram."

And so MARC became known as the most user-friendly—but still granular!—content standard of all, adopted by all information professionals in all fields. And to Tiny Tim, who soon acquired broader, narrower, and related headings, he became almost a mentor.

He was always known as one who kept the spirit of Banned Book Week in his heart. Let us all follow his example.

For, as Tiny Tim said, "Ours is essentially a tragic age, so we refuse to take it tragically!"

THE END.

CONTRIBUTORS

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Zach Welhouse ate too much plastic candy. His work has appeared in publications about Amazonian river dolphins, mischievous pixies, and himself. He can be contacted by dropping an egg in a forgotten well or on Twitter (**@ZachRPG**).

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orccupations

by RJ Edwards

Archivist Orc

"I'm not actually good with the colour markers but I wanted to make it clear that the archivist orc is wearing gloves. Also his name is Artemis Bonefolder."

Follow @RJmakes on Twitter to see more orccupations! Poet, entomologist, orthodontist, bartender, ice cream scooper, athletic team mascot, dog walker, unpaid intern, and more.